the micro level. They looked at finance, business reviews, human resources and corporate assurances.

The members of the GEO were handpicked by Ratan. They were highly accomplished professionals. From within the group, it had its best financial brains—Noshir A. Soonawala and Ishaat Hussain. From outside, the ones inducted were R. Gopalakrishnan, Kishor Chaukar—former MD of ICICI Securities and Finance Company Ltd who later joined the Tatas as the MD of TIL—and Manab Bose, who was in the senior management of General Electric. Their remit was the articulation, implementation and review of the entire gamut of the strategies incubated by the chairman.

The GEO's responsibilities were so vast that it played an influential role in almost all aspects of management, human resources, corporate governance, financial reporting and sustainability. To help the members perform these roles more efficiently, they were also made directors of the boards of the major companies. This created a powerful link between the chairman and the individual companies and helped Ratan closely monitor and steer the affairs of the companies through the directors who reported directly to him.

After the GEO was established, Ratan consolidated the activities of the various companies. He put an end to 'overlapping businesses' and restructured the group into seven business verticals—energy, engineering, materials, chemicals, services, communications and information technology, and consumer goods.

This grouping helped the companies in each segment to exist in a synergistic architecture, drawing from each other the technology, expertise and experience that existed in individual companies but were not previously shared. At the macro level, the business verticals drew succour from each other through osmotic exchanges, facilitated by the GEO playing the role of a significant catalyst.

As Ratan articulated, the primary task of the body 'was to look at the strategic direction' of each of the group companies and to set certain tasks for their overall growth 'based on historical growth trends, as also industry leadership in terms of being number one, two or three'. And if the companies could not achieve these ranks, then Tata Sons would consider divesting from them.

Another remit of the body was to assess the unique value that a company could bring to a particular business vertical and also what the group could